



UNPLEASENT AFFAIR Maliwal leaves the CM's residence after the recreation of the incident, May 17; (inset) Bibhav Kumar after his arrest, May 20

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where the two have an alliance—go to the polls. All bets will be off in the last phase of the Punjab polls, where they are pitted against each other.

All this a far cry from the events of May 10, when Maliwal was one of the AAP members waiting outside Tihar jail and celebrating Kejriwal's temporary release, even declaring to TV cameras, "We will win, and we will win with a huge margin." Now she has even removed his photo from her social media profile on X, and is accusing the party she helped found of tarnishing her character and shielding a man who allegedly assaulted her. AAP, in turn, says Maliwal has become a "BJP pawn" to prevent Kejriwal from campaigning. They claim that the BJP is leveraging an ongoing corruption case against her. "Maliwal is facing an alleged recruitment scam case from the Anti-Corruption Bureau involving contractual staff for the DCW," senior AAP leader Atishi said. "The BJP seems to be applying its formula of filing cases against leaders on her. She has been in touch with them for months. Check her call records."

But what exactly happened on May 13. What is undisputed is that Maliawal arrived that morning at the CM's residence (apparently without an appointment) at around 8.40 am. Initially stopped by security, she persisted and gained entry into the drawing room. What happened between 9.10 am and 9.33 am is unclear. At 9.34 am, Maliwal called the police control room and went to the Civil Lines police station but left without filing a complaint, citing extreme trauma and unwillingness to politicise the incident. It later came to light that Maliwal, a former chief of the Delhi Commission of Women (DCW), had said in her statement to the police that Bibhav "slapped me 7-8 times while I screamed...." AAP condemned Bibhav's actions the next day, with fellow Rajya Sabha MP Sanjay Singh saying Kejriwal had ordered strict action against him. Singh also visited Maliwal, though details remain undisclosed.

On May 16, Maliwal filed an FIR, and broke her silence on X: "What happened to me was very bad. I have given my statement to the police. I hope appropriate action will be taken. There is a special request to BJP people to not do politics on this incident." But the next day, a video clip surfaced, purportedly showing an agitated Maliwal in the CM's house, demanding to speak to senior police officers. AAP's stand had shifted dramatically by then, with Atishi claiming, "Swati Maliwal's intention was to accuse the CM, but he was not available, so he was saved... that video has exposed her lies."

On May 17, Bibhav himself filed a counter-complaint, alleging that Maliwal became angry when he told her Kejriwal was unavailable and threatened to ruin his life. After the video, Maliwal accused "political hitman" Bibhav of orchestrating the leak and insisted the CCTV footage would disclose the truth. The police told the court that the CCTV footage of the CM's house has been wiped clean as is Bibhav's phone. On May 18, AAP released a video clip, claiming it was CCTV footage of the day. It shows security personnel escorting Maliwal out. "She is walking steadily, without a hint of any assault or pain," Atishi said at the presser. "She even misbehaves with a female police personnel on her way out."

Texts and calls to Maliwal and Bibhav went unanswered. Both have had a long association with Kejriwal—Bibhav is his closest aide and wields significant power in the party; Maliwal has known him since his days in the NGO Parivartan and the India Against Corruption movement. But despite her achievements, newer leaders have overshadowed Maliwal within AAP. Political watchers say her Rajya Sabha ticket seemed insufficient compensation.

Her absence during most of Kejriwal's stay in prison also did not escape the party's notice. She was in the US for her sister's treatment, a fact that led BJP's Amit Malviya to say that AAP was a "sinking ship". Indeed, none of

THE SAGA HAS GIVEN THE BJP A STICK TO BEAT AAP WITH AND COUNTER THE NARRATIVE THAT THE PARTY HAS BUILT AROUND KEJRIWAL'S ARREST

AAP's Rajya Sabha MPs, except Sanjay Singh—himself out on bail in the excise policy case—and AAP general secretary Sandeep Pathak, was found protesting Kejriwal's arrest. Raghav Chadha, in London for an eye treatment, met Kejriwal after his return on May 18.

Meanwhile, stung by the accusation of being a "BJP pawn", Maliwal posted on X: "Leaders who joined the party yesterday declared a 20-year-old worker as a BJP agent." On May 21, Delhi Lieutenant Governor V.K. Saxena, who is forever at odds with the AAP regime, also put out a statement: "It is most disturbing to note that the alleged scene of crime was the drawing room of the CM, even while he was present in the house.... I would have expected that at least for the sake of propriety, my CM would have come clean, rather than being evasive and dodgy." The whole shabby incident serves the BJP well for the moment; whether anyone will be interested in resolving it after the election is another matter. ■

with Kaushik Deka and Anilesh S. Mahajan